

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Muhammad Azeem Khan

Address: 9 Bicknoller Close Sutton SM2 5NQ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am a student currently residing at an address in SM2 5NQ and write to express my strong support for the proposed BASMA community facility at the former Sutton Ambulance Station on Dorset Road. As a young person living in this community, I write with a particular perspective on what this facility would mean for residents of my generation, and for the long-term future of this neighbourhood.

The proposal reuses an existing brownfield public service site with a modest extension, improved landscaping, cycle parking and onsite car parking. Technical reports show that most existing users already walk, that parking stress on surrounding streets is well below capacity, and that staggered Friday prayer times and marshalled onsite parking will avoid conflict with school dropoff and pickup. Noise assessment work demonstrates that activities inside a wellinsulated, singlestorey building will remain below existing background levels and will be quieter than the former 24hour ambulance use.

Youth Programmes and Structured Activities:

As a student, I have seen firsthand how critical structured, accessible, and affordable activities are for young people in Sutton. The provision of youth programmes, whether educational workshops, mentoring, sports, arts, or social clubs, gives young people direction, builds confidence, and creates the kind of community bonds that help individuals thrive. The SM2 and Belmont area has a growing young population, yet community provision specifically designed for young people is severely limited. The proposed BASMA facility, with its explicit focus on youth engagement, fills this gap directly. I would personally benefit from and enthusiastically participate in the programmes

this centre aims to deliver.

Education and Supporting Students:

Students like me often require support that goes beyond university or college provision, mentoring, study spaces, career guidance, and peer networks. A community facility that offers educational programming and structured learning support is invaluable to young people navigating higher education, employment applications, and professional development. I am especially supportive of the Use Class F1 (Learning and Non-Residential Institutions) dimension of this proposal, which reflects the centre's ambition to be a genuine educational hub for the whole community.

Wellbeing and Mental Health:

Student life is not without its pressures, and isolation during periods of study is a growing concern nationally. A local community centre within walking distance provides an accessible, welcoming environment where young people can take a break, socialise, engage in wellbeing activities, and find peer support. The wellbeing initiatives proposed by BASMA, including fitness sessions and health programmes already being trialled by the community, are particularly relevant to students and young adults who often fall through the gaps of formal support services.

Inter-Community Interaction and Social Cohesion:

I am part of a generation that genuinely values diversity, mutual understanding, and cross-community dialogue. I believe that community centres run by established charities like BASMA, which has served this community with professionalism and care since 2020, are among the most effective platforms for fostering inter-community interaction. A permanent, well-resourced facility on Dorset Road would allow BASMA to host open events, cultural exchanges, and community partnerships that reach well beyond its own congregation, strengthening the social fabric of the entire SM2 area.

3 halls are proposed - 1 for ladies, 1 for prayers and 1 for multi-use which is for all communities. There will be a publicly available defibrillator which is a vital life saving device.

Supporting People Who May Be Lonely or Isolated:

Living in a residential area and studying, I see around me many neighbours, particularly elderly residents and those living alone, who lack regular social contact and structured social engagement. Community facilities that offer regular, friendly activities are the backbone of community wellbeing. I fully support the ambition of this facility to be a place where isolated residents of all ages can find connection, support, and a sense of belonging.

Repurposing a Vacant Site for Community Benefit:

The former ambulance station on Dorset Road has been vacant since its closure. From a planning perspective, the repurposing of a redundant civic building into an active community facility is precisely the kind of sustainable, socially beneficial development that the Sutton Local Plan and the National Planning Policy Framework encourage. Rather than allowing a community asset to fall into disuse or be converted to less publicly beneficial uses, this application proposes to breathe new life into the site in a way that serves thousands of residents.

I write as a young resident and student who has a genuine stake in the future of this community. I urge the Planning Authority to grant planning permission for this application, which will deliver lasting benefits for people of all ages, backgrounds, and walks of life in Sutton.

Yours faithfully,

Azeem Khan